ARTIST COMMONS

HOW TO CRIT BETTER

CORE AGREEMENTS

ASSUME GOODWILL

We're here to help each other grow.

MULTIPLE READINGS CAN COEXIST

Your interpretation is a viewpoint, not the final truth.

BE PRECISE

Specific statements beat vague ones every time.

CONFIDENTIAL

What's shared in cohort stays in cohort.

PARTICIPATION GUIDELINES

1

NO MONOLOGUES

Cap any single comment to 30–45 seconds.

2

RAISE HANDS

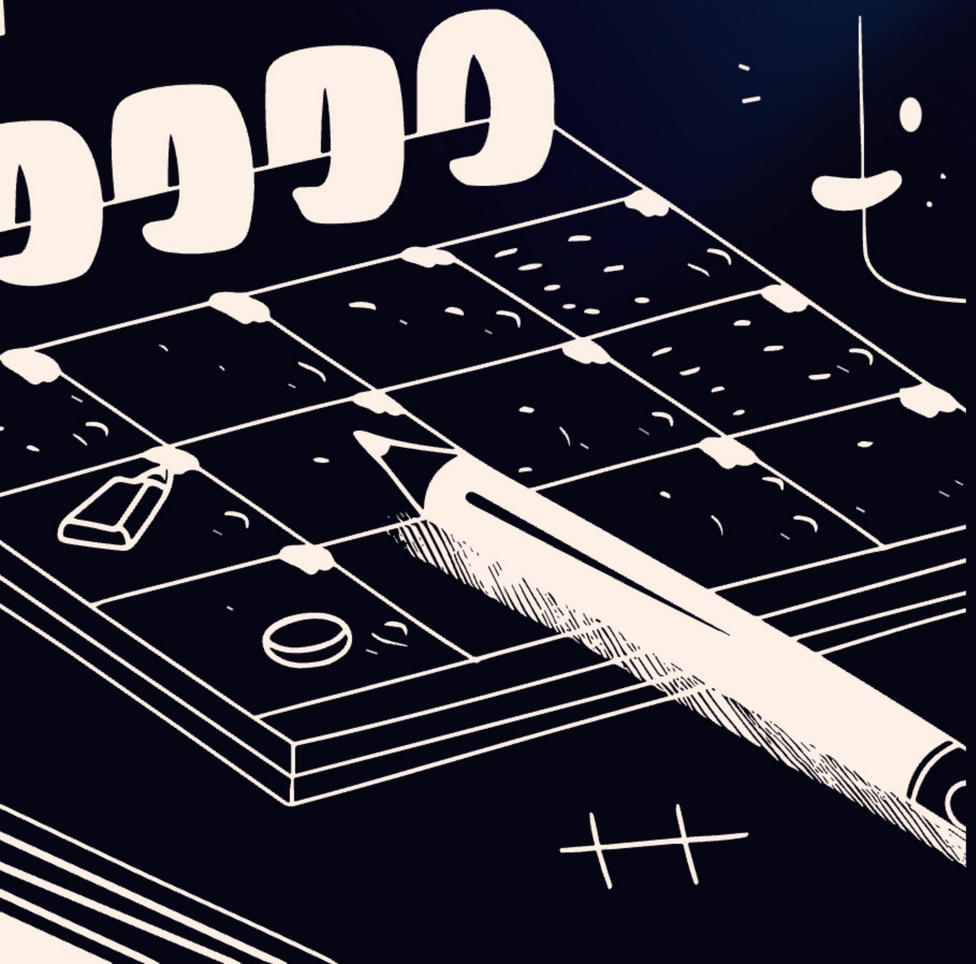
Your mentor will call on you in the order they see hands.

Don't raise your hand again until you've seen that everyone has gone at least once.

3

QUIET MEMBERS

Quiet members should commit to at least 2 contributions per presenting artist.



SHARE THE ARTWORK 24–48 HOURS BEFORE YOUR COHORT FEEDBACK SESSION

Don't share any text or explanations.

4 COMPONENTS TO CLOSE LOOKING

OBSERVATION

What do you see/hear?

EFFECT

What did it do to you as a viewer?

EVIDENCE

What in the work caused that reaction?

UNRESOLVED QUESTIONS

What did the work leave you wondering about?



THE LANGUAGE WE SHOULD USE

USE "I" STATEMENTS

"I notice..."
"I'm confused by..."
"I'm curious about..."

BACK UP YOUR PERSPECTIVE WITH EVIDENCE

"I felt _____ because..."

"Because the lighting does _____, I read it as..."

NO CERTAINTY LANGUAGE

"Obviously"
"Always"
"Never"
"Everyone will..."

USE "PERHAPS" OR "MIGHT" OR "ONE POSSIBILITY"

Avoid should statements like: "you should do _____"

Instead open a path of possibility: "I would be curious to see what would happen if..."

CRITIQUE CRAFT CHOICES, NOT THE PERSON

This includes not critiquing their motives or taste:

MOTIVE

Don't ascribe motive or psychologize them.
"You're afraid to..." or "You want attention..."

TASTE

Don't impose your taste or judge other people's taste.
"I don't like digital art" or "I don't get abstract art"
is not feedback.

THE ARTIST'S RIGHTS



THE ARTIST CAN ASK FOR WHAT THEY NEED

Request more craft notes, more talk about the meaning of the work, or just questions.



THE ARTIST DOESN'T NEED TO RESPOND TO ALL FEEDBACK

Simply say "Noted" and move on (no debate required).



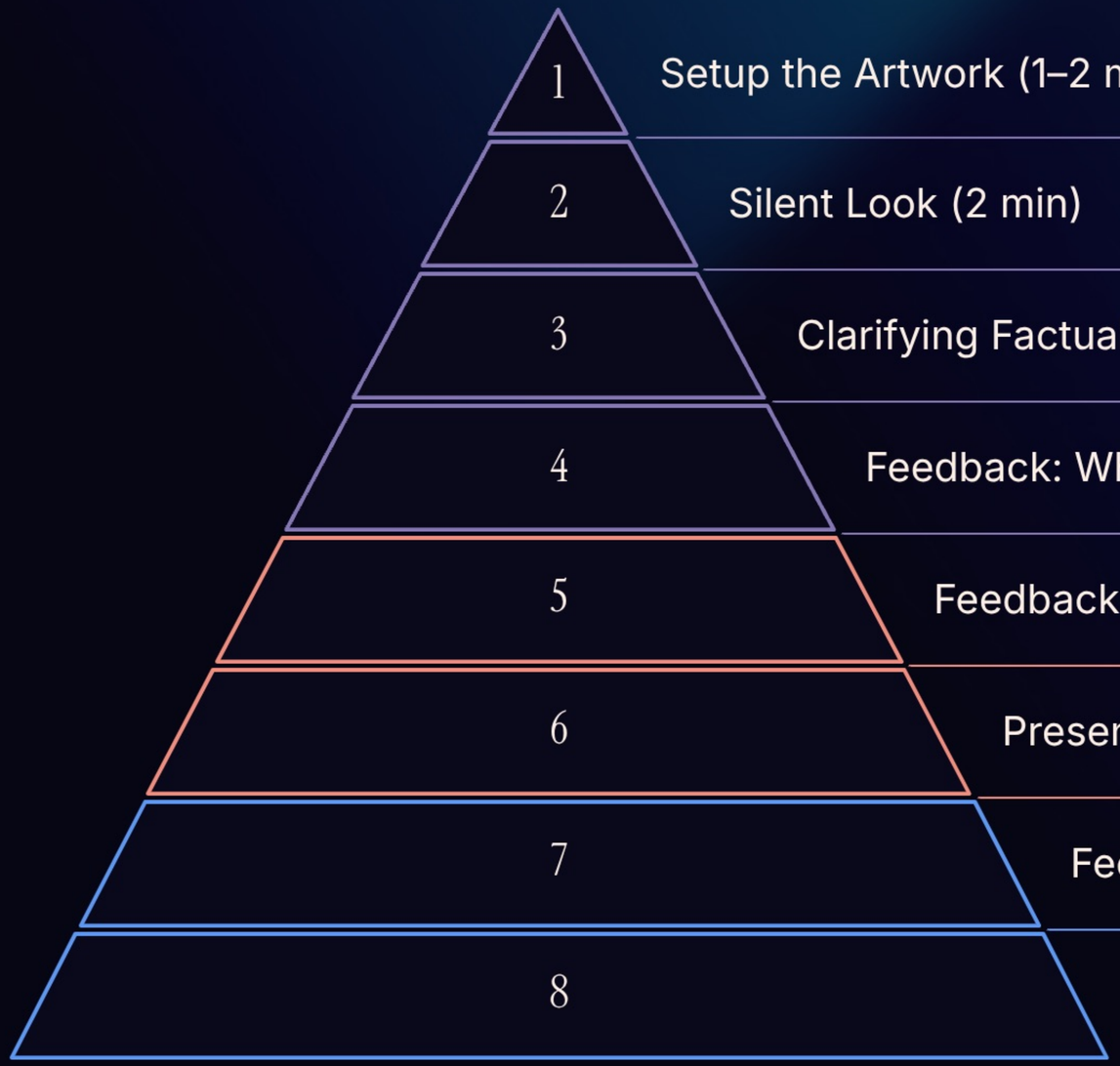
THE ARTIST CAN HIT PAUSE

You can pause the feedback session if it becomes unproductive or unsafe.



The Presenting Artist always has power here. This Feedback Session is for you. We are for you. We are here to help you get out of your head. To help you see your work more clearly. To help reveal that there are a multitude of perspectives and relationships to any image. The goal is better next steps, not perfect consensus.

FEEDBACK FRAMEWORK (52 MIN)



1. Setup the Artwork (1–2 min)
2. Silent Look (2 min)
3. Clarifying Factual Questions (5 min)
4. Feedback: What's Working and Why (10 min)
5. Feedback: What is this about & how it makes meaning? (5 min)
6. Presenting Artist: Intended Effect & Key Questions (7 min)
7. Feedback: What Could Be Stronger (18 min)
8. Presenting Artist: Synthesis + Commitments (3 min)

1. SETUP THE ARTWORK

1–2 MIN

1. **WHAT THIS IS**
   Title/series/context
2. **WHAT STAGE IT'S IN**
   Early/later draft
3. **WHERE TO LOOK**
   How to access or navigate

Rule: *These are only the logistics the group needs to look (number of images, order is fixed or flexible, is sound on/off, etc.) No sharing intent, meaning, or goals. You won't get a neutral read on the work if you do.*

EXAMPLE: ARTWORK SETUP

This is called *Time Explorations*. These pieces are part of a series of digital works. There are eight images here made over the last few weeks. I'm looking to release it online for collectors in about two months. This is about a dozen hours of work, but it still feels like an early draft.

Make sure you click the diagonal arrow in the corner so you're seeing it full-screen when you look. You can use the arrow keys to flip through.

WHAT THE SETUP TIME IS NOT FOR

1. Explaining Intent or Meaning

2. A long backstory

3. Self-deprecating framing

   "This is bad," "Sorry it's not ready," "I hate it."
   It nudges the group toward reassurance instead of analysis.

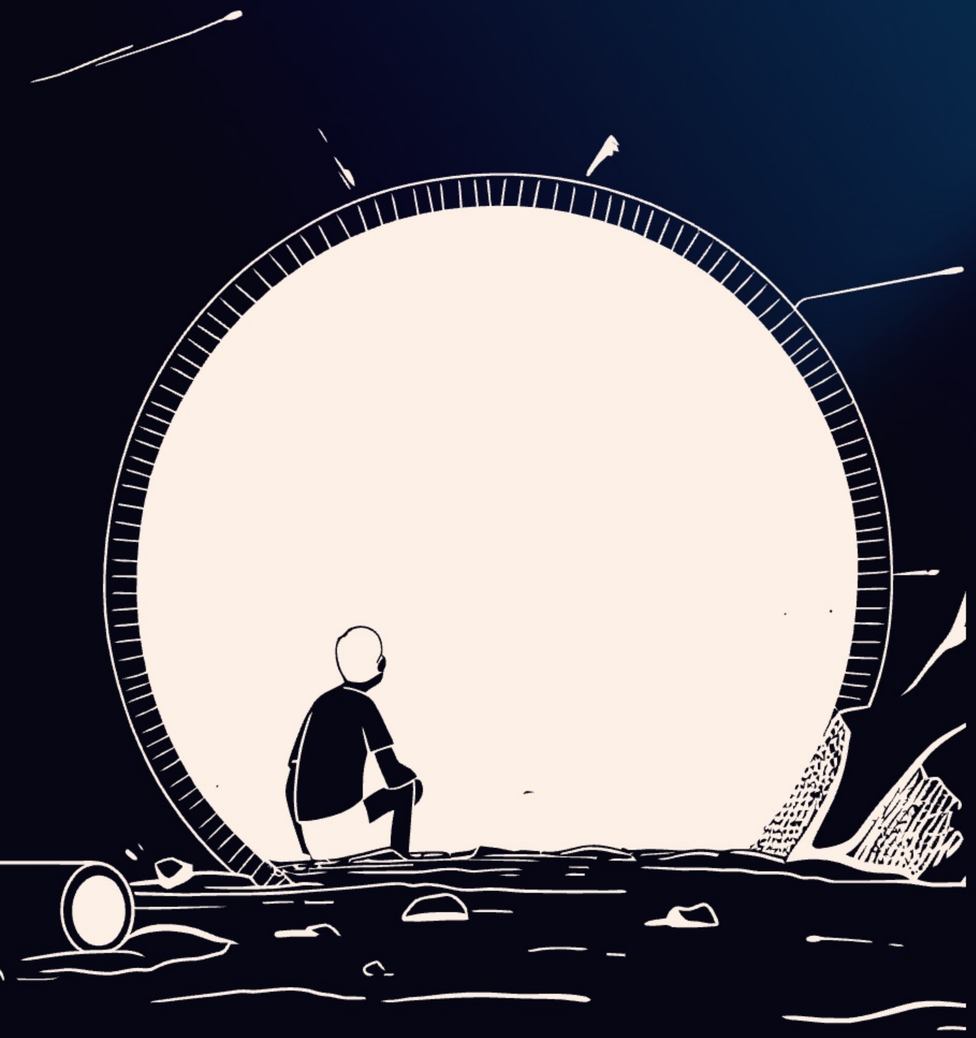
You made something. Let the work speak. We care about you. Let us come in neutral so we can see it most clearly and be most helpful to you.

2. SILENT LOOK

2 MIN

Everyone looks without speaking. Use the Four Components of Close Looking to make notes for later stages. This is a chance to slow down from our usual pace and way of looking.





WHAT TO AVOID DOING DURING THE SILENT LOOK

- No reactions out loud: "wow," "I love this," "I'm confused."
- No feedback or clarifying questions (yet).
- No advice in chat or side messaging.

Rule: no talking until the silent look is done.

SIMPLE PROMPTS FOR TAKING NOTES

"I NOTICE..."

"I'M DRAWN TO..."

"I WONDER..."

THESE COULD INCLUDE

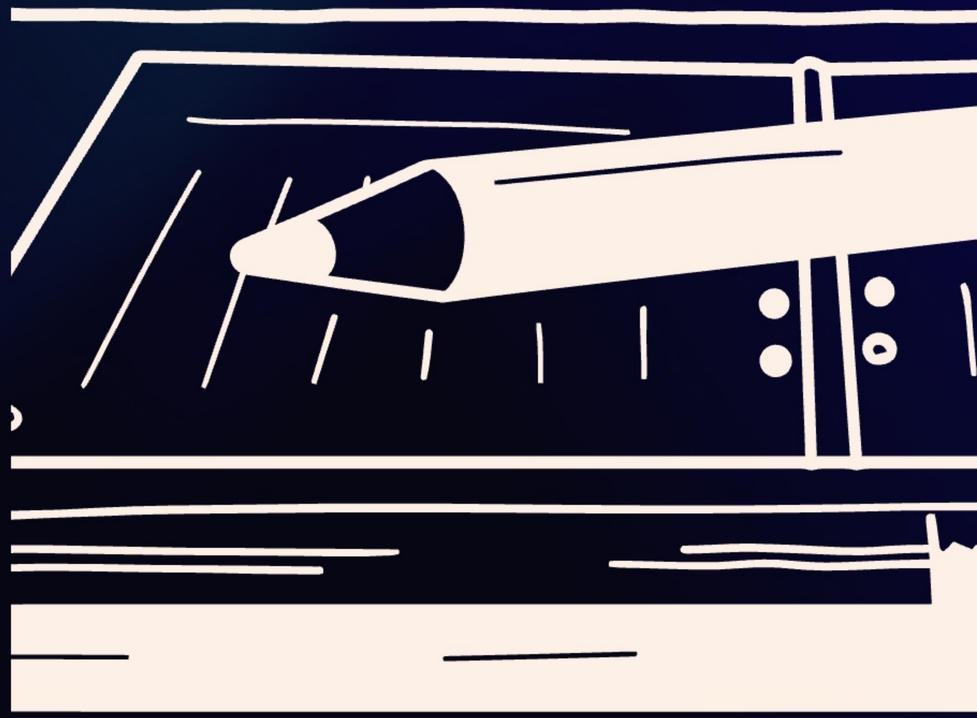
Where your attention goes first

Repetition, such as forms, colors, gestures, motifs

Visual shifts in tone, scale, rhythm, density, space

What feels most alive or a moment that holds you

What you're unsure about



3. CLARIFYING FACTUAL QUESTIONS

5 MIN

These are **what** and **how** questions. Clarifying questions are for clarifying our shared understanding of the work and to help make sure everyone in the group is seeing the same work clearly and accurately before we move on to interpretation.



CLARIFYING QUESTIONS ARE



FACTUAL

What, where, when, how



NON-LEADING

They do not imply what should change



PHYSICAL

Materials, size, process, sequence, constraints



ANSWERABLE QUICKLY

Ideally 1 sentence long

Think: *"What do I need to know to read this clearly?"*

EXAMPLE: CLARIFYING FACTUAL QUESTIONS

- What's the intended format (print, web, installation)?
- What size is this in the real world?
- Is this the final order?
- What materials or tools did you use?
- What parts are hand-made and which are not?
- Any limits you're working within?

- What is fixed and what is still flexible?
- Do you have any hard deadlines or submission requirements?
- Is there accompanying text or should it stand alone?
- Where will this be encountered and who is the intended audience?

WHAT CLARIFYING QUESTIONS ARE NOT

INTERPRETATION QUESTIONS

- "What does the red represent?"
- "Is this about grief?"
- "What did you have in mind when...?"

Interpretation comes later, when the group reports what they read in the work.

OPINIONS DISGUISED AS QUESTIONS

- "Don't you think it would be stronger if...?"
- "Have you considered making it less...?"
- "Isn't the problem that...?"
- "Why didn't you just...?"

PRESENTING ARTIST: GUIDELINES FOR HOW TO ANSWER

ANSWER IN 1–2 SENTENCES

IF YOU FEEL PULLED INTO MEANING

Say: "Hold that for later."

IF THE QUESTION IS OUTSIDE TODAY'S SCOPE

"That's not my focus for today, so it's not decided yet."

IF YOU DON'T KNOW

"I'm not sure yet."
That's a valid answer.



CLARIFYING FACTUAL QUESTIONS ONLY.

No opinions yet. No praise, no critique, no advice. We're just information-gathering to make sure we all know what we're looking at. "Just the facts ma'am."

4. FEEDBACK: WHAT'S WORKING AND WHY

10 MIN

Our first opportunity for feedback is about what is landing, not what should change. You're sharing with the artist what you found resonant, exciting, or memorable about a work-in-progress. We start with positive and non-judgmental feedback that is specific to build trust and empower the artist before we move into a deeper critique.

1. Share a "what's working" or "what's strong" statement that is specific and grounded in evidence.

2. Tell the Presenting Artist what was striking about the work. ("I like...")

A GOOD "WHAT'S WORKING" RESPONSE HAS 3 PARTS:

01

OBSERVATION

What you saw/heard

02

EFFECT

What it did to you as a viewer

03

EVIDENCE

What in the work caused that effect

Simple formula: "I notice _____. It made me _____. Because _____."

EXAMPLES

"I notice the repeated horizon line. It made me feel steadier, because it anchors each image even when the landscape changes."

"I like the pacing from image 2 to 3. It made the shift feel dramatic, because the negative space opens up."

"I love how the sound sits under the voice. It made the piece feel intimate, because that mixing choice puts the voice in the foreground."

SUGGESTIONS FOR WHAT TO COMMENT ON

A) VIEWER EXPERIENCE

- What grabbed your attention first?
- Where did your eye go next?
- What stayed with you after looking?

B) CRAFT AND FORMAL CHOICES

- Composition, palette, scale, rhythm, sequencing
- Material handling, finish, clarity, consistency
- Where tension is created and resolved

C) MEANING AND READING (WITHOUT INTENT CLAIMS)

- What themes or questions you read
- What emotions or atmosphere the work carries
- What feels ambiguous in a productive way

D) COHESION AND VOICE

- What makes it feel like "this artist"
- What feels consistent across the series
- What feels newly specific or sharpened here

WHAT'S NOT HELPFUL

VAGUE PRAISE

- "It's beautiful." "It's cool." "Nice work."
- If it's true, make it useful by naming why.

EVALUATION LANGUAGE

- "This fails." "This is weak."
- The goal is to be descriptive and responsive, not judgmental.

ADVICE OR SUGGESTIONS

- "I like it, but you should..."
- "This would be stronger if..."
- "Have you considered..."

It's too early for advice and suggestions. There will be lots of space for those in a later stage.

THE ARTIST'S ROLE WHILE HEARING FEEDBACK

LET YOURSELF RECEIVE.

This round of feedback is about how the work is already reaching people.

Take notes on what resonated. Especially if you hear something you hadn't realized about the work.



5. FEEDBACK: WHAT'S THIS ABOUT & HOW DOES IT MAKE MEANING?

5 MIN

This round is about what the work is communicating right now — what it's saying and how it's saying it. Many artists do not begin with a fully formed artist statement. Meaning often arrives through making. This step gives the artist a mirror for how much of what they put into the work is coming across.

We do this before the artist weighs in, and thereby weights how we're viewing the piece when, in the next round, they describe their intended effect and Key Questions. Right now is about naming what we think the work is doing, saying, or asking to help the artist hear that early meaning.

OPERATIVE QUESTION: WHAT DO YOU THINK THIS IS ABOUT?

1. CLAIM

What you think it's about

2. EVIDENCE

What in the work led you there

Formula: "I read this as communicating _____ because _____."

6. PRESENTING ARTIST: INTENDED EFFECT & KEY QUESTIONS

7 MIN

This round is where the feedback session becomes **artist-led**. As the Presenting Artist, you finally get to share the intended effect of the work and the context behind it. You then choose what kind of help you want by asking 1–2 Key Questions. The group responds to your Key Questions.

In sharingn the context of the work, the goal is not to cover every decision you made. Our goal is to get clarity on the pivotal choices that led the work here and the possible paths still before you.

IN THIS ROUND, THE PRESENTING ARTIST WILL DO TWO THINGS

STATE YOUR "EFFECT SENTENCE"

Describe in one sentence what you want the viewer to experience, understand, or feel when they encounter the work. What is your intended effect?

DESCRIBE THE CONTEXT

In a minute or two, describe the context behind the piece(s). Keep it simple. The more you speak here the less time there is for you to receive feedback. Only say what is absolutely necessary.

ASK 2–3 KEY QUESTIONS

Each question should focus on a single decision embodied in the work. Our aim is to sharpen pivotal choices you made with clear, actionable feedback.

You're encouraged to come prepared with your 2–3 Key Questions. Though you can change them as you hear feedback.
The Cohort responds to the Key Questions you asked.

A STRONG KEY QUESTION IS

SINGULAR

One concern/choice per question.

SPECIFIC

e.g. it's about attention, clarity, tension, pacing, cohesion, etc.

ANSWERABLE

Each question should be something a viewer can answer from what they see in the work. They shouldn't have to guess, Google it, or ask you to explain further.

DECISION DRIVEN

It will clarify which direction to take.

EXAMPLES: KEY QUESTIONS

- "Where does your attention go first, then second?"
- "Does X feel consistent across the series?"
- "Does Y help the emotional tone land?"
- "What looks least resolved right now?"
- "What feels unclear or underdeveloped?"



WHEN ASKING KEY QUESTIONS:

ASK ONE KEY QUESTION AT A TIME.

Asking multiple key questions at once overwhelms listeners. They can't hold them all in their memory. The result is confusion and can often lead to shallower answers.

AVOID LEADING QUESTIONS

"Do you see how it's about grief and surveillance capitalism?"

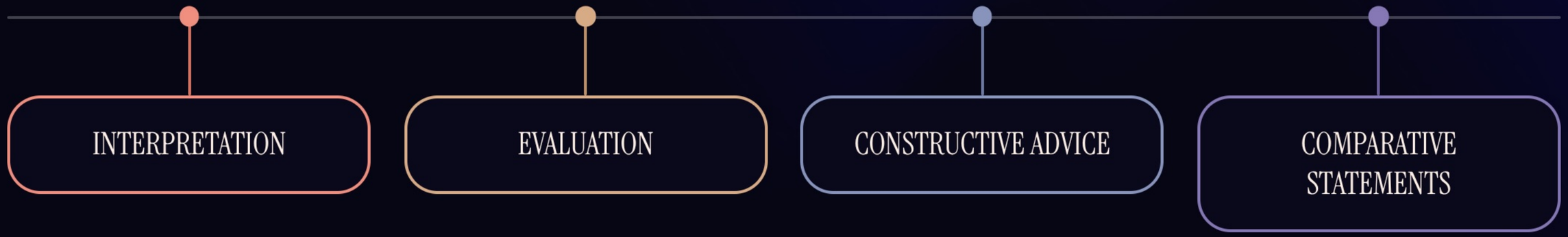
Ask neutral questions instead, so you don't accidentally box viewers into one way of seeing.

7. FEEDBACK: WHAT COULD BE STRONGER

18 MIN

This last round of feedback is where we move from what is already working to what might strengthen the work next. Our goal isn't to redesign the project. Our goal is to offer a small number of clear, high-value possibilities that the artist can experiment with next.

In this round, we offer:



THREE TYPES OF FEEDBACK YOU CAN OFFER

INTERPRETATION & EVALUATION

- "I think the work gains/loses energy when..."
- "For me, the part that feels most/least coherent is..."

CONSTRUCTIVE ADVICE

- "It might be worth trying..."
- "I'd be curious what happens if..."
- "Perhaps the next step could be..."
- "One adjustment that might help is..."
- "It could be interesting to see what happens if..."

COMPARATIVE STATEMENTS

- "For me, compared to the rest of the works in the series, this piece carries more weight because..."
- "This one appears to answer a different question than the others because..."
- "I think this image is perhaps the strongest/weakest link right now to bridge these two sections because..."
- "Perhaps this output, more than these others, points a way forward for the rest of the project because..."

ALL FEEDBACK YOU OFFER SHOULD:

1

FRAMED AS JUST YOUR PERSPECTIVE

Using "I" and "perhaps" statements.

2

BACKED UP WITH EVIDENCE

"Because I see in the work..."

3

OFFER POTENTIAL DIRECTIONS TO EXPLORE AND EXPERIMENT

"Perhaps" and "might" offer a branching path of possibilities.

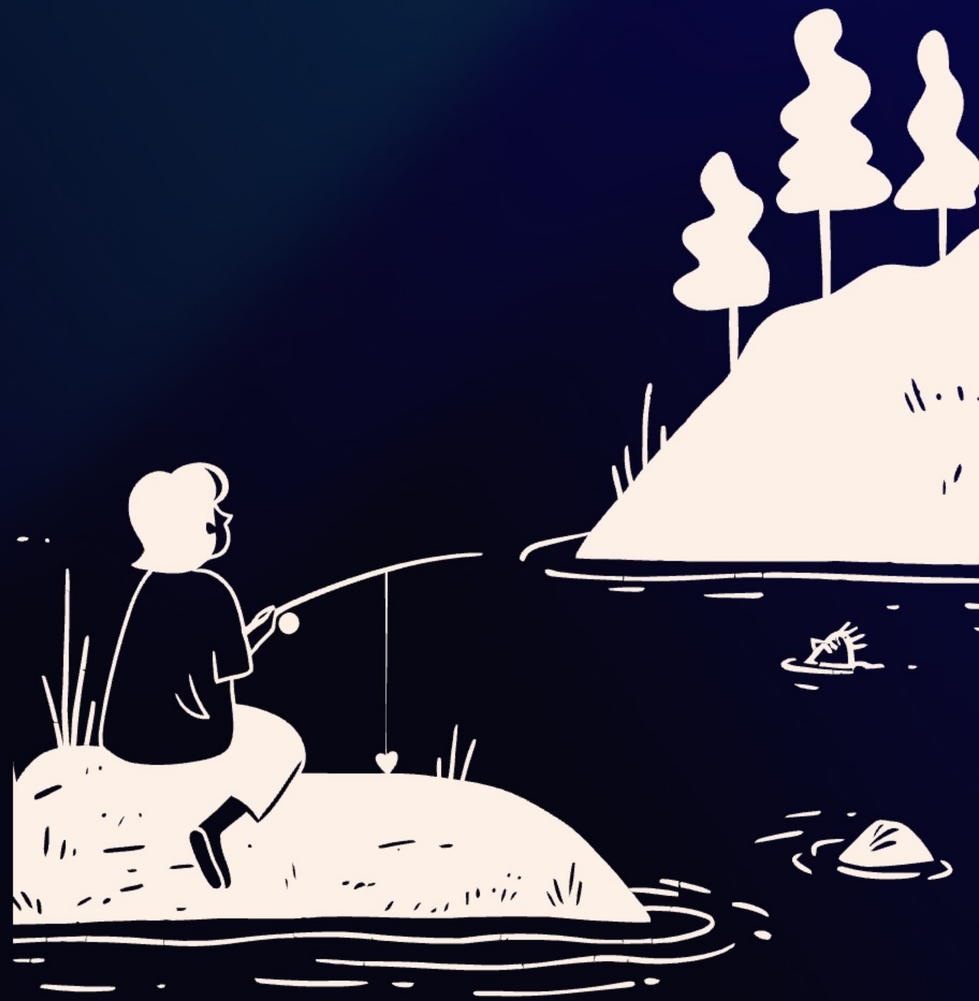
EXAMPLE: WHAT COULD BE STRONGER

> "In this abstract piece, the palette reads quiet, almost restrained, because the values are so close together. It creates a sense of calm for me. But my eye never finds anything to anchor on to keep my attention in the frame. I want to linger, because I like the colors, but I'm finding it hard. I'm curious what would happen if you experimented with adding a couple high-contrast accents to create some clearer points of interest for the viewer. Maybe that would help me linger longer."

8. PRESENTING ARTIST: SYNTHESIS & COMMITMENTS

3 MIN

This is a time for the Presenting Artist to reflect and lock in the useful feedback in their memory for after the session. The goal is not to defend the work or answer every comment. The goal is to turn what you heard into clear next steps.



PRESENTING ARTIST SYNTHESIZES WITH TWO PROMPTS

- "What I'm taking away..."

- "Two concrete explorations or experiments I want to commit to try before next time are..."

Rule: The Presenting Artist doesn't debate feedback. They name the useful parts and gently leave the rest behind.

WHAT I'M TAKING

Name the strongest things you heard. Keep it specific.

STRONG PROMPTS:

- "The pattern I noticed in your feedback was..."
- "The biggest surprise for me was..."
- "The most helpful clarification I got is..."
- "What I want to preserve as I revise this is..."
- "The tension I want to lean into is..."
- "The choice I'm more confident about after hearing you is..."
- "The question I want to keep working with is..."

COMMIT TO TWO EXPERIMENTS OR EXPLORATIONS

A good experiment/exploration is:

1. **SPECIFIC**
   It has a clear goal and everyone will be able to tell if you did it.

2. **LIMITED AND REALISTIC**
   It fits in your available time and resources.

3. **USEFUL EVEN IF IT FAILS**
   It teaches you something.

EXPLORATION PROMPTS

- "Before next time, I'm going to experiment with..."
- "I'll make two contrasting versions to explore where..."
- "I'm going to remove/add/shift _____ and see what changes."
- "I'm plan to try a variation that pushes _____."

ACCOUNTABILITY:

- "I'll post a progress update in the cohort WIP channel by _____."



WHAT THIS REFLECTION TIME IS NOT FOR

- Re-explaining intent or the backstory
- Responding to each person's comment
- Asking the group new questions (save that for the cohort text chat)

EXAMPLE: TAKEAWAYS & EXPLORATIONS

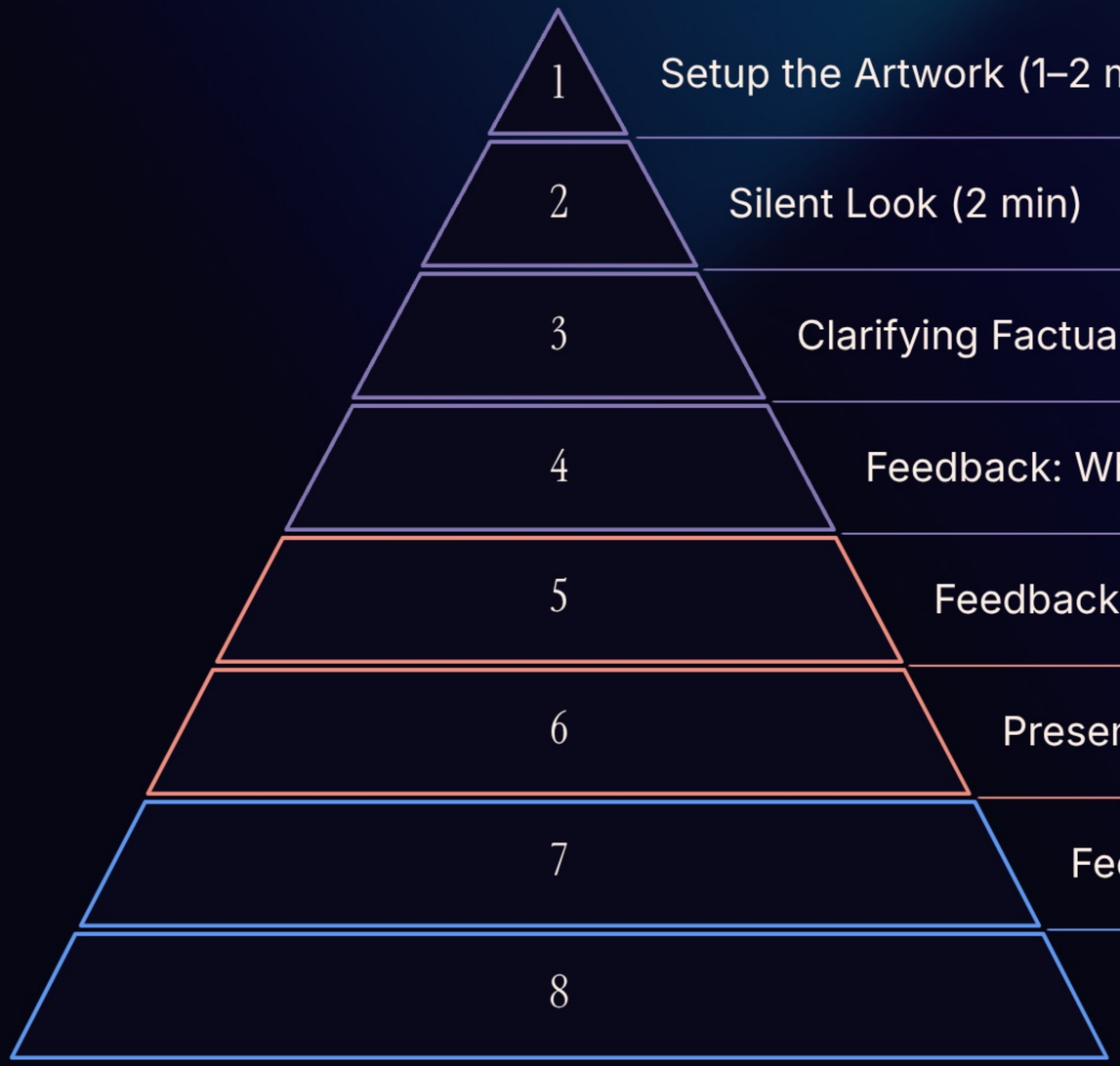
WHAT I'M TAKING

Thanks for the kind words about the palettes, but I hear you on the tension between the soft washes and the lack of solid forms. That's something definitely something I see now and I'm taking away as something to work on.

EXPLORATIONS

I'm committing to making two studies next, one with some accent marks to define the space more, and one without, but using the same composition so I can A/B test and compare how that affects where your eye goes. I'll post it in the WIP channel and I can't wait to get your take on them.

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